THE UNIVERSITY OF SYDNEY

DMBA 6001 Leading Strategic Digital Transformation

From Bookings to Blockchain: Trust in Hospitality's Digital Future

(OpenAI, 2026)

Trust is critical in the hospitality ecosystem

Trust is the core value of the hospitality industry. We see trust between hotels, guests, and payment providers. The emergence of digital platforms has distributed trust across a multitude of systems working accurately and consistently together (World Economic Forum, 2024). Trust is at the heart of the hospitality ecosystem; even small delays in reservation data or payments can deeply hinder customer confidence and operational stability. Blockchain can ultimately bridge the gap in this pivotal intersection in the evolution of digital trust through its potential to reshape digital trust (Tapscott & Tapscott, 2018).

Blockchain changes where trust sits

The core foundation of blockchain lies in a shared digital ledger centred around transparency and immutability (Casino et al., 2019). Blockchain's real power is its ability to enable the verification of transactions and records without a centralised authority (World Economic Forum, 2024). The hospitality industry, however, still relies on centralised authorities to manage booking confirmations, payments and dispute resolutions. Ultimately, this centralisation opens the door for blockchain to show its true value. By decentralising the establishment and maintenance of trust, blockchain can provide a more efficient, resilient, and transparent mechanism for trust in the hospitality ecosystem.

When major institutions move trust on-chain

Blockchains growing credibility is becoming more evident through the emergence of major institutions moving trust on-chain. This is evident through Blackrock's launch of its tokenised fund, *BUIDL* - providing its investors with an on-chain investment apparatus aimed at delivering stable yields against the US dollar. BUIDL highlights a significant message towards the wider industry; that blockchain can be a viable infrastructure for on-chain trust. Ultimately, if established financial institutions like Blackrock can embed these new digital technologies around trust management, hospitality incumbents (and newcomers) should also look to expand their horizons into the blockchain realm.

(BlackRock, 2024)

What this could mean for hospitality leaders

For hospitality leaders, blockchain has the potential to strengthen booking and reservation verification, increase transparency around payments, and ultimately reduce disputes and friction between customers and hoteliers across the ecosystem. However, blockchain adoption in hospitality still needs to cross the hurdles of governance, regulatory bodies and whether hospitality partners are willing to evolve move towards a shared blockchain infrastructure. These hurdles move blockchain away from being just another “trend” and instead positions it as a key strategic question centred around trust architecture.

Trust is being rebuilt, not removed

Ultimately, blockchain promulgates the core notion that digital transformation is not just about speed and efficiency, but instead its focus lies in the importance of being able to rethink how trust can be created, verified and governed in an era where digital ecosystems are constantly evolving (Tapscott & Tapscott, 2018).

For hospitality companies traversing through the ever-evolving digital landscape, it can be argued that the key lies in redesigning an old traditional trust infrastructure into one that can support multiple avenues across bookings & reservations, payments and partner relationships (World Economic Forum, 2024).

Reference List

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Contact

aryan.gupta@sydney.edu.au

agup0543